

Episode 192: Summer Vacation 1970

When this manuscript is updated, it'll probably be around the Obon period. By then the London Olympics will be over, and while gently soaking in that afterglow, everyone will be doing hometown visits or summer vacation trips, perhaps? Summer vacation like that. This week is a summer vacation special, so "*Mawaru Penguindrum* Colour Design Notes" is taking a break (laugh).

Now then.

Since both my wife and I were born and raised in Tokyo, our household doesn't have major events like "hometown visits." Furthermore, I had no "countryside experience" as a boy, and in elementary school I was somewhat envious when classmates would go play in the "countryside." Oh, come to think of it, I asked my mother "Why don't we have a countryside?" - this was when I was in lower elementary school.

During elementary school, my summer vacation in Tokyo's Nakano was morning glories, radio callisthenics, school pool, and morning anime.

First, waking up at 6 AM. "Which ones bloomed this morning?" Our house grew many varieties of morning glories in pots every year, and seeing different coloured flowers bloom each morning was incredibly enjoyable. Our house's morning glories were mainly large-flowered varieties. For many long years, we properly collected seeds every year, organised them in small bags with notes (like "Purple large-flowered variegated"), and the following year we'd plant seeds at the right time for summer morning enjoyment.

After making the rounds of the veranda morning glories, I'd go to the nearby middle school grounds. NHK radio callisthenics started at 6:30. There was a "radio callisthenics card" that hung from your neck on a string, and you'd get stamps after doing callisthenics each day. It was somehow mandated by the neighbourhood association until July 31st - about 10 days from the start of summer vacation - and if you had perfect attendance you'd get something commemorative. A pencil or notebook or something.

The reason it was just July from the beginning of summer vacation was probably a measure to make children maintain regular lives during vacation. Radio callisthenics continued in the middle school grounds throughout summer vacation after August 1st too, but I never went (laugh). I was probably getting up fairly early, but why? I never went (laugh).

Then I'd return for breakfast. And help with cleaning as my mother instructed. When finished it was usually 9 o'clock.

I don't know how elementary schools are now, but in our era, school pools were open to students during summer vacation. Ah, "open" is misleading. There were schedules like "pool classes" roughly 1-2 hours each, morning and afternoon, I think organised by every two grades - not exactly classes but loosely like that. I'd go to school flip-flopping in beach sandals with swim trunks, bath towel, and swimming cap (!) in a vinyl bag.

Honestly I didn't really like pools (laugh). Sure it'd be cool if you could swim, but I thought it was fine if you couldn't swim (laugh), but somehow on pool days going to the pool became top priority, so I'd flip-flop my way there.

There was another reason I somehow didn't want to go to that school pool. Actually, when there was pool in the morning, I couldn't watch morning anime.

Back then in Tokyo during summer vacation weekday mornings, from about 10 o'clock for an hour or hour and a half, they'd show anime reruns. Current TV Asahi was broadcasting them quite actively. "Summer Vacation Children's Theatres" or something like that. Dubbed American anime like *Wacky Races*, *Tom Thumb*, *King Kong*, *Dora Dora Kitten* and *Chaka Chaka Girl*, *Super Three*. And Japanese ones like *Sally the Witch*, *Secret Akko-chan*, *Flower's Pyun Pyun Maru*. They kept showing such things.

This was really my enjoyment. Not just summer vacation, but winter and spring breaks had anime programming too, but winter and spring breaks are unfortunately short. So

depending on the work, broadcasts would naturally end partway through. Well, programming-wise they were broadcasting as "masterpiece selections," but we wanted to watch everything! So summer vacation with its long broadcast period was quite high points!

Regardless of summer vacation, each broadcasting station had anime rerun slots in evening hours too, but since you could watch anime from morning (AM), that was really happy!

So to watch anime during that time without getting complaints from parents, I'd properly finish daily studies and summer vacation workbooks beforehand, then settle in front of the TV fully prepared (laugh). Thanks more to morning anime than early morning radio callisthenics, I was able to live regularly during summer vacation - such were my elementary school days (laugh).

Incidentally, what was I doing in the afternoons? I was chasing cicadas with a bug-catching net (laugh). Since store-bought bug nets don't reach very high places, I'd extend the pole myself and catch cicadas crying high up on tree trunks. In the evenings I'd water the garden plants while getting mosquito bites, and about once a week we'd do fireworks at night (laugh). Our household didn't go to beaches, had no "countryside" visits, no summer vacation trips, but I still got quite tanned.

Ah, it's an old man's past flashback (laugh). Happy memories, good recollections.

What kind of summer vacation lives do today's elementary students have? Since my wife and I don't have children, I don't really understand that part. Ah, now there are probably active extracurricular activities like soccer? Or cram school attendance? Compared to my childhood there are probably many more fun things, but still, I think summer vacation should broadcast anime for elementary students every morning!

